

Is there really a Big Two in men's tennis? Or is it more a monopoly than a duopoly? After all, if Jannik Sinner had converted any of his three championship points against Carlos Alcaraz in the epic French Open final, he would now hold all four Majors. Alcaraz had defeated his arch-rival five straight times before Sinner dethroned him in the Wimbledon final, but the Italian is the undisputed King of Hard Courts. Another burning question at this U.S. Open is whether anyone else in the 128-player field can upset either of the putative Big Two, who've snarfed up the last seven Grand Slam titles. Let's survey the field and size up the favourites, contenders, and dark horses.

Ben Shelton — Ben Shelton's confidence is soaring after capturing the National Bank Open in Toronto with a come-from-behind 6-7(5), 6-4, 7-6(3) victory over No. 12 Karen Khachanov. For the third time, he triumphed in a clutch third-set tiebreak, the others over Flavio Cobolli and Brandon Nakashima. The 22-year-old Shelton thus became the youngest American man to claim a Masters 1000 title since 21-year-old Andy Roddick took the 2004 Miami Open.

Shelton's best result at the last seven Majors came at the Australian Open in January, when he reached the semis, where Sinner outclassed him 7-6(2), 6-2, 6-2. Despite a career-high No. 6 ranking, Shelton has beaten only two top-10 opponents, Taylor Fritz and Alex De Minaur (twice), this year. The weakest backhand in the top 10, along with an erratic volley and forehand, hampers the 6'4", 195-pound American. Until his technique improves on these three strokes, Shelton will not have a shot at winning a Major — even on hard courts, his best surface.

Novak Djokovic — The GOAT's quest for a record 25th Grand Slam title — which would break his tie with Margaret Court — became more uncertain when he withdrew from the Cincinnati Open. That left the No. 7 with no tournament matches between Wimbledon and the year's final Major. Is Djokovic (**right**) injured? Does he lack motivation? Does he believe it's mission impossible? "They're definitely several levels above everyone right now," said 38-year-old Djokovic about Sinner and Alcaraz after Sinner outclassed him, slowed by a hip injury, 6-3, 6-3, 6-4 in the Big W semifinals.

If any champion can overcome the lack of match play for nearly two months, it is the man

renowned for his superb technique and fitness. A decisive loss to Sinner or Alcaraz — or even worse, a lesser foe — could persuade the last of the legendary Big Three to hang up his tennis shoes and end his unparalleled 22-year career. Alas, that is more than likely not to happen at Flushing Meadows. The Djoker has surprised us before, most recently when he captured a gold medal at the Paris Olympics. So, who knows what he can accomplish in the late twilight of his career?

Taylor Fritz — A year ago at Flushing Meadows, Fritz made his first Grand Slam semifinal thanks to excellent wins over 2022 finalist Casper Ruud and Alexander Zverev. When he overcame Frances Tiafoe in a five-set semifinal, it marked the first time two American men reached the U.S. Open semis since Andre Agassi and Robby Ginepri in 2006. Hopes soared for Fritz to become the first American man to capture a singles Major since Roddick won the U.S. Open way back in 2003.

But his hopes were dashed when Sinner, far superior from the baseline, won a resounding 6-3, 6-4, 7-5. Although his ranking has climbed to a career-high No. 4 this year, Fritz has notched only two top-10 wins — over No. 3 Zverev in Stuttgart on grass and No. 8 Rublev in Toronto on hard court. However the 6'5" mega-server fell short in the Wimbledon semis, losing 6-4, 5-7, 6-3, 7-6(6) to No. 2 Alcaraz.

Winning tiebreaks is critical, especially against 'the top guys', and he will have to improve on his mediocre 16-19 record this



AFP